

Introduction

"Why am I here?"

I was six years old when the question found me.

It was a Sunday morning. I was at my study table, homework open in front of me, half-finished. My mother moved through the house the way she always did, into one room, out with something in her hand, into another, into the kitchen. It was the kind of motion that becomes invisible because it never stops. I looked up from my notebook and watched her for a moment.

And then, without warning, a question entered the room and sat down across from me.

Why?

Why was she doing all of it? Why was I doing my homework? She would finish lunch. I will finish my page. Tomorrow would arrive, and we would do it again. But why?

I didn't have language for what had just happened to me. I only knew that something had shifted. I understood, in the blunt way children understand things, that one day I would die, and if that was true, what was all of this in between actually for?

Nobody could have answered it. I know that now. But back then, I just knew the question wasn't leaving. It had pulled up a chair, and it intended to stay.

So I did what children do when a feeling has nowhere to go. I closed my notebook. I went on with the day, and the day after, and all the days that came stacked behind it, and I told myself I had simply outgrown the question.

But the truth is that I had only stopped asking it out loud.

There were many other tables after that one. A desk in a classroom, where I learned that being clever felt safer than being curious. A desk in an office, years later, where I signed things and drank coffee gone cold and mistook being busy for being alive. A table set for two, then more, where I played the roles I'd been handed down - daughter, partner, IAS officer, mother, so well that even I started believing that I had finally decoded life and now that six-year-old who had been overwhelmed with an existential question, won't tag along anymore. Little did I know that in my desire to fit in, I had only silenced her.

I didn't think of that little girl again, until, decades later, at a café.

I wasn't looking for anything. I was watching people the way you watch rain, without purpose. People drifting in and out. At the table next to me sat an elderly man and a young boy, facing each other. The boy spoke animatedly about school, about how his best friend no longer wanted

to play with him. The man just listened. He didn't interrupt or try to fix anything. He simply nodded, eyes soft with understanding.

And in that moment, I saw something quietly beautiful, two generations sitting across the same table, separated by decades, yet bound by the same feeling, the ache to be understood, the need to belong.

I couldn't stop watching them. I knew that boy. I had been there, long time ago, asking a different question. And I found myself wondering if the old man also was carrying a question of his own somewhere. Maybe that's what growing old actually is. Not running out of questions, but running out of the energy to keep asking them out loud.

That's when it hit me that people live their lives like waves: rising, falling, rising again. I've done it myself more times than I can count. Over the years, I've come to notice a pattern: every life unfolds in phases. Childhood, adolescence, adulthood, old age. But we rarely pause to truly understand these transitions. We just keep going.

And then one day, we look back and wonder. "*Where did it all go?*" It's a sudden realization: a quiet existential crisis, where we find ourselves asking,

"Is this all there is to it?"

Life keeps changing. People change. Roles change. Circumstances change. But the questions remain. They simply return wearing different clothes

This book is what happened when I finally decided to go back to the moment when it all started.

It Matters A Lot is not a book of answers. It is an invitation back to the question, the one you probably asked once too, before someone told you it was better to keep it quiet.

Each chapter in this book sits with a different stage of life, childhood, adolescence, adulthood, old age, not to tell you how to live it, but to slow you down inside it.

To ask what a child actually needs when she says she wants to be heard. What a teenager is really chasing when he says he wants to be free. What an adult means when he says he's tired, and what an elderly man is really doing when he simply listens to a boy talk about a friend who doesn't want to play with him anymore.

I don't want you to read this book like a manual. There's no script to follow. If anything, the book will ask you to put the script down for a while, the one about degrees and lifestyles and milestones, and just look at the life you're actually living underneath it.

There is nothing in these pages that will help you fix your life or tell you what it should look like. Because life never adds up to be a perfect, coherent whole. And maybe, it's not meant to be. We keep trying to "figure it all out", but what if life isn't a puzzle to be solved, but an

experience to be lived? When you begin to accept uncertainty as part of the journey, something softens. You stop seeking control and begin to evolve.

I want this book to stay with you like an old friend. Some pages will remind you of places you've already been. Some will meet you exactly where you are. And some will quietly point toward where you're headed. Somewhere along this journey, I hope you find at least one question that stays with you. Because there is a difference between existing and truly living, and most of us only come to know this towards the end. Through this book, let's discover what we are doing. Merely Existing or truly living.

So fasten your seatbelts, for a journey that brings you closer to who you truly are.
